

They will train at the ICC Cricket Academy grounds and commute 30 kilometres to Sharjah for their matches. Abu Dhabi was not considered this time due to prior commitments to hosting a bilateral series between Ireland and South Africa.

Allardice emphasised the UAE's diversity as one of its standout features: "One of the exciting things about the UAE is its diversity. It's a place where the entire world is represented, and that's why there will be quite a bit of crowd support."

Organising such a massive event on short notice, however, is no easy task. "It came as a surprise, but we are used to such surprises," said Mazhar Khan, General Manager of Sharjah Cricket Stadium.

One major challenge for Dubai and Sharjah was getting the grounds ready in peak summer, with temperatures soaring to nearly 50 degrees Celsius. "When the news came in, it was peak summer, so we had to prepare the grounds. Thankfully, with no games in between, the pitches were well-rested and are now ready," said Khan, a seasoned administrator. "We are quite used to these situations because, in the UAE, there is a lot of coordination between the ECB and

the venues — Dubai and Sharjah. The teamwork helps overcome the initial challenges."

With the ICC headquartered in Dubai, coordination is streamlined, avoiding unnecessary delays in execution. Administrators familiar with the UAE's transformation from a distant vantage agree that "smooth operations and excellent government support" are the cornerstones of the UAE's success.

"We've been able to deliver successful events every time due to the immense support of our government and the wealth of experience in staging such events. The UAE has hosted cricket matches for over 40 years. With that kind of experience, it becomes easier to manage logistical and security challenges," pointed out Zaid Abbas, a board member of the ECB.

While Dubai International Stadium has not hosted a match recently, Sharjah Stadium held three T20 Internationals between Afghanistan and South Africa, serving as the perfect lead-up to the World Cup. "The grounds are in good shape, a new scoreboard has been installed, and new lights are in place — everything is ready for the showpiece

event," Khan added.

Last year, the men's Asia Cup was played in a hybrid model, with Pakistan and Sri Lanka hosting two legs. There were many logistical challenges for the cricket boards and the teams, with lots of travelling from one city to another.

"Last-minute changes make it a logistical nightmare," Ahmed says. "But with the UAE, travelling is easy, and it is convenient in terms of access to the best facilities, hospitality, and everything else. That certainly makes the UAE a go-to destination for any global events, and over the years, it has lived up to the expectations."

Since the onset of the pandemic, the UAE has taken on the responsibility of hosting several major sporting events — MMA, BWF badminton series, IPL, PSL (Pakistan Super League), and Asia Cup — and each time, the nation has delivered a flawless experience.

As the UAE prepares to host the Women's T20 World Cup, it is determined to uphold its sterling reputation for delivering world-class events.

Last-minute change: The 2024 Women's T20 World Cup was moved from Bangladesh to the United Arab Emirates following civil unrest in the original host country. GETTY IMAGES

Despite being an **ICC associate member**, the UAE has become a prime cricket destination and an alternative venue for major events in times of crisis, as seen with this year's Women's T20 World Cup.